

Learn to Be a Great Communicator: Relationships Matter, Featuring John Horton

John Horton, Executive Coach

Pat said ...

Coach Pat Summitt

“I know my reputation. I’m that lady who’s so mean to those poor young women.”

John Horton, Executive Coach

However, if you really knew Pat and her players, you would realize that perception is not always reality. Pat said, “Off the court is an entirely different matter. You have to see the inside of our team structure and understand our relationships to understand why I speak to them the way I do and how they transfer it. Off the court, I’m a confidant and a substitute mother. In that situation, my chief role is to listen, advise, and comfort.”

The bottom line is relationships matter. People need to see and feel who you are to feel connected to the work you want them to do. Don’t be known only by your emails and official messages. Show up in person as often as possible. Balance high tech with high touch. Show your human side!

In 1978, management guru Tom Peters was a consultant for McKinsey and Company, working on a project with a relatively small and largely unknown electronics company, Hewlett Packard. There, he discovered a powerful leadership and communication practice they called “management by walking around.” This may not seem like managing at all. Yet, at its heart, it’s about being there in person, conversing face to face.

Pat said, “Listening has allowed me to be a better coach. You have to listen to develop effective, meaningful relationships with people. The more I’ve listened to our players, the better I have known them and understood them.”

Good leaders are good communicators and good communicators are good listeners. When you listen well, you gain a clear understanding of another’s perspective and knowledge. Listening fosters trust, respect, and openness.

Finally, never underestimate the power of the written word. Pat was a master at writing notes, not email, but old-school, handwritten notes. Pat said, “Words on paper, it struck me, have more meaning than something spoken aloud. They have permanence. I could say something 25 times, but when they read it once, it seemed to make a difference.”

So, how will you build relationships with your team so that they are loyal to you, committed to what you're trying to accomplish, and willingly follow your lead?